

MECKLENBURG NEIGHBORS

WEDNESDAY, FEBRUARY 5, 1992

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In south Charlotte . . .
Supporters of the Marion Diehl Recreation Center say programs for the disabled are being neglected. Meanwhile, a long-awaited laundry center may finally be installed. . . . **Pages 18-19**



Helping the hungry . . .
Two new food pantries for the poor open as the annual "Charlotte Has Heart" food drive starts. . . . **Page 4**



On Carmel Road . . .
After two years of planning, three public meetings and 25 group meetings, the "most controversial road widening in recent years" will go before the city council. . . **Page 8**

In the schools . . .
Interested in optional schools? The annual application period has been delayed as officials discuss creating "magnet" schools. . . . **Page 2**

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TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

Bring the birds home to roost: Pat Marcum, director of the Carolina Raptor Center, whose new building is taking shape

rapidly at Latta Plantation Park, examines one of the center's permanent residents, Zinnia, a common barn owl.

Off to a flying start

New raptor center right on schedule

By PAT BORDEN GUBBINS
Staff Writer

If the Carolina Raptor Center moves into its new \$220,000 home by April 1, it's going to cost one of its board members a wad of money.

If that deadline is met, Charlotte lawyer Kent Brown has promised to take the entire 12-member board and the center's major donors, Fred and Edna Moretti, to the restaurant of the Moretti's choice.

"And it looks like we're on schedule," said raptor center Director Pat Marcum, as she toured the two-story, 4,000-square-foot building on a recent afternoon.

Brown's challenge is the type of

volunteer spirit that has helped the raptor center thrive in tight economic times when other nonprofit groups are faltering.

The success of the new center, at Latta Plantation Park in northern Mecklenburg County, may revolve around something as simple as a love of wildlife.

"I'm just in love with animals, birds of prey in particular," said Edna Moretti, a former volunteer who encouraged her husband to make a \$100,000 donation toward the building.

"I think the raptor center does so much good," she said. "Education is the key. If people had more respect and understanding of animals, they wouldn't do some of the

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Volunteers take project under their wing

Raptor

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things they did."

Zinnia, a common barn owl, is an example of well-meant but damaging human intervention.

"People got her when she was young and tried to raise her as a pet," said Marcum, holding the exquisitely feathered owl on her arm. "She imprinted on humans, which means she doesn't know she's an owl. They didn't feed her properly, so she developed rickets."

As a result, both wings are deformed. Zinnia could not survive on her own, so she'll live out her life at the raptor center. But she earns her keep in several ways.

She is a valuable teaching tool for the center's educational programs. "And she is a wonderful surrogate mother," Marcum said.

Hundreds of birds

The center took in about 500 birds last year, including orphaned birds that need mothering, and hosts of injured and sick birds in need of medical care. Most are released back into the wild. Unreleasable birds such as Zinnia will remain to educate people about the value and natural splendor of raptors — eagles, owls, buzzards, hawks and falcons.

About 100 loyal volunteers feed the birds, clean their cages, give programs and perform a multitude of other essential tasks. They include people such as Jim Arthur, a retired vice president of Hoechst-Celanese. He lives on Lake Wylie, a 30-mile drive to the raptor center.



Arthur

"I'd heard of the raptor center and was generally aware of what they were doing," he said. "I had intended for some time to go see what they were doing."

"About two and a half years ago, an associate of mine who was on the raptor center board asked if I'd be interested in being on the board."

Arthur was installed six months after he retired and just as the new building project was being launched. "I was asked to serve as the coordinator of that, and I've been doing it ever since," he said. On average these days, as the center nears completion, he volunteers about 30 hours and drives at least 300 miles each week.

"He's been just wonderful, making sure everything has been done and on time," said Marcum. "I'd like to have three or four more just like him."

Thanks to its volunteers, board of directors and dedicated staff of five, the raptor center knows how



Almost home: Pat Marcum, director of the Carolina Raptor Center, peers into what will be the base of the new aviary under construction at the entrance to the center.

to make it through hard times.

"I remember in 1987, when the county said they were going to cut out all funding for the raptor center," said Marcum. "We thought it was the end of the world. But we were determined to survive."

How to earn money

The center diversified its means of earning money, from selling T-shirts adorned with donated art work, an "adopt-a-bird" program to help cover expenses, to selling personalized bricks at \$35 each for walkways and patios at the new building.

"It has really helped us to get through something that has caused

a lot of heartache for a lot of nonprofits," Marcum said. "A lot of them no longer exist. But we had to learn to stand on our own two feet. Or maybe I should say, 'Our own 200 feet.'"

Moretti's gift couldn't have come at a better time, she said. The center has been operating out of two trailers set back in the woods off Sample Road. One is used for office space, and the other serves as a hospital.

"With a staff of five, plus our volunteers, we were bursting at the seams," she said. "We were getting so crowded it was hard for us to function."

Moretti, who owns a construction company in Charlotte, made

his offer just as the center's board had finished drawing up a 10-year plan in 1990. Among the goals was to start work on a new building.

Moretti offered to donate the money if the raptor center raised the rest.

His gift created a challenge. "When Mr. Moretti walked up and said he was going to do that, we didn't know what we were going to do," Marcum said. "We never had a capital fund drive before."

They quickly figured out the first step: They needed drawings of how the building would look to stir interest among potential donors.

Architect Herbert Lawton met with the staff to get its ideas and



Bright home: A large skylight brightens the exhibit hall at the new environmental center.

drew up a design concept for the center at no cost. With those drawings, board members set out to visit corporations to ask for help. Using the design concept, architect Floyd Kay Jr. drew the working blueprints and donated them to the center.

Many, many donations

"At last count, we had raised \$238,000, including the Moretti's money and in-kind donations," Marcum said. Gifts came from as far south as Spartanburg and as far north as Hickory.

"I've always said this is going to be the environmental center that North Carolina built," said Marcum.

In-kind donations include built-in cabinets and desks by Creative Woodcrafters Inc., gravel from Martin Marietta Aggregates, a well by McCall Brothers Well Drilling, a pump and tank from Crawford Well & Pump Service of Huntersville, a crane for steel erection by Joel Carter of Huntersville, ceramic floor tile from Reynolds Distributing, grading by Neill Grading Co. of Hickory, underlayment by Hoechst Celanese Spun Bond Division of Spartanburg, stone hauling by Wooten Trucking of Hickory, set and finish stone work by Superior Paving of Hickory and a roof ventilator from Robert E. Mason & Co.

Richard Gibson of Lake Wylie is creating two circular stained-glass works he will donate to the center.

About 20 members of the Painting & Decorating Contractors of America will spend a weekend of their own time staining the exterior and painting the interior of the building.

And in the meantime, the board and volunteers are still out there, raising money to operate the building and pay the staff. "We hope to add a part-time bookkeeper and a maintenance person," Marcum said.

"We still have a \$160,000 budget (to meet operating expenses). We have to literally watch every penny."

Photos by TOM FRANKLIN/Staff